

Morphology and word-formation

Lexicology and Lexicography – **Course Website**

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Outline

1. **Lexical innovation**: How do new words arise and what are the key types?
2. **Morphology vs word-formation**: What's the distinction and scope?
3. **Inflection in Present-Day English**: What inflectional morphemes exist?
4. **Morphological building blocks**: What are morphemes and their categories?
5. **Morphemic processes**: How do derivation and compounding work?
6. **Non-morphemic processes**: What are conversion, clipping, blending, back-formation, and acronyms?
7. **Practice**: How can we analyse word structure?

Introduction

Lexical innovation

How do new words arise?

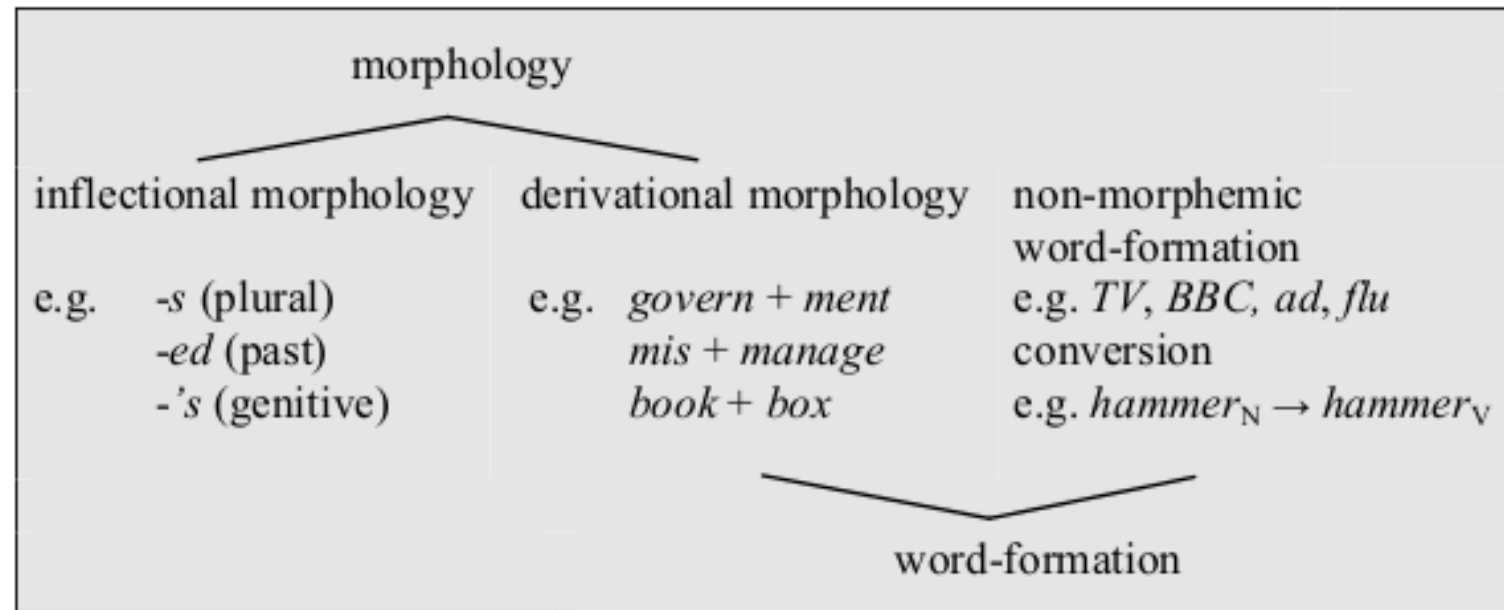
Kerremans ([2015](#))

		meaning	
		old	new
form	old	x	<i>subprime</i>
	new	<i>snowicane</i>	<i>detweet</i>

Morphology vs word-formation

What is the difference between morphology and word-formation?

Schmid (2016)



Inflection in Present-Day English

Which inflectional morphemes exist in Present-Day English?

Schmid (2016)

word class	morpheme	functions/meanings
noun	{plural}	marking of plural
verb	{genitive}	marking of genitive; possession, part-of etc.
	{3 rd person}	3 rd person singular present
	{ing}	present participle
	{ed ₁ }	simple past
adjective	{ed ₂ }	past participle
	{er}	comparative
	{est}	superlative
numerals	{th}	ordinal number

Morphemic word-formation processes

Morphological building blocks

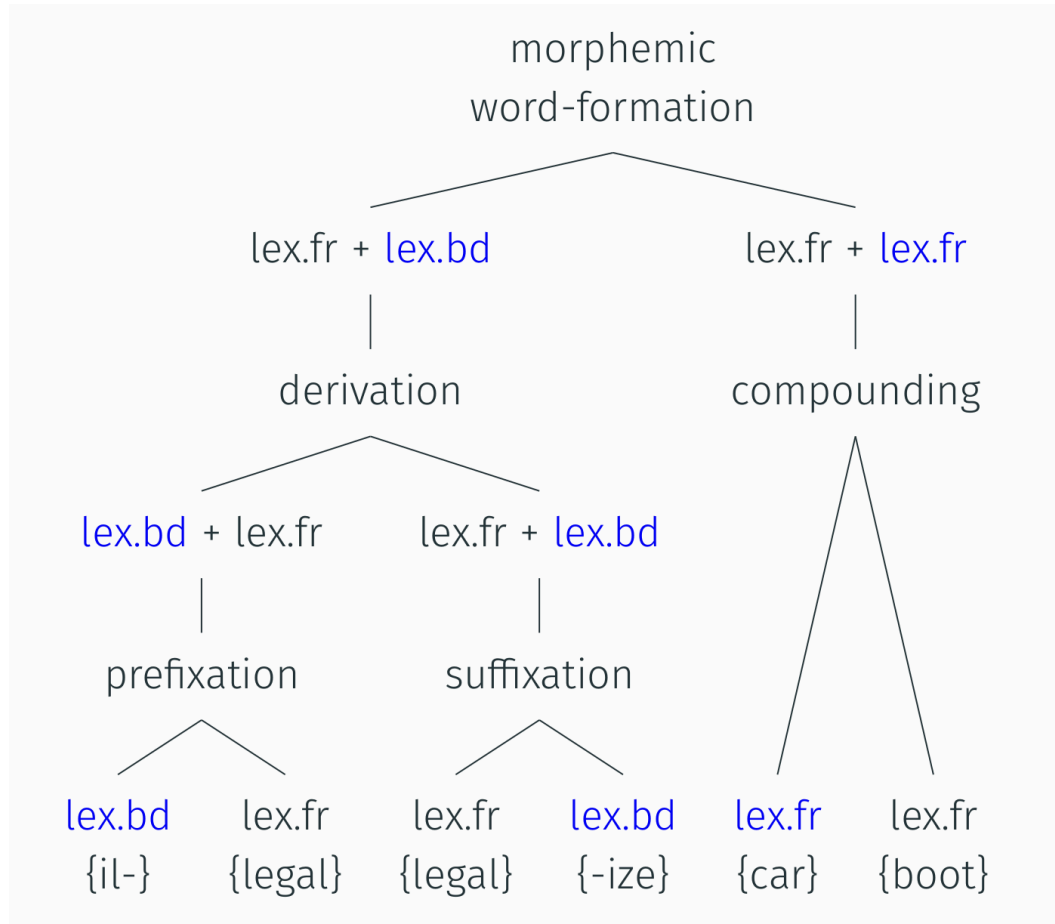
Which types of morphemes are there and how do they differ?

Schmid (2016)

morpheme class	attributes	examples
lexically free (lexemes, roots)	• semantically autonomous • open class • inflecting (except for interjections)	N: {head}, {key}, {part} Adj: {green}, {pale}, {nice} Adv: {fast}, {well}, {here} V lex: {plan}, {teach}, {pass} Interj: {ouch}, {damn}
grammatically free (lexemes, function words)	• not autonomous, relational • closed class • not inflecting	V aux: {will}, {must}, {have} Pron: {she}, {which}, {why} Prep: {of}, {in}, {at} Conj: {and}, {that}, {as} Num: {one}, {thousand}
lexically bound (derivational affixes)	• (more or less) open class • create lexemes with discrete meaning • usually change word class (suffixes) • closer to the stem	prefixes: {re-}, {dis-}, {post-} suffixes: {-er}, {-ify}, {-ment}
grammatically bound (inflectional suffixes)	• closed class • create word-forms with unchanged meaning • always maintain word class • further away from the stem	for Ns: {plural}, {genitive} for Vs: {3 rd pers. pres. sg.}, {ing}, {ed ₁ }, {ed ₂ } for Adjs: {er}, {est} for Nums: {th}

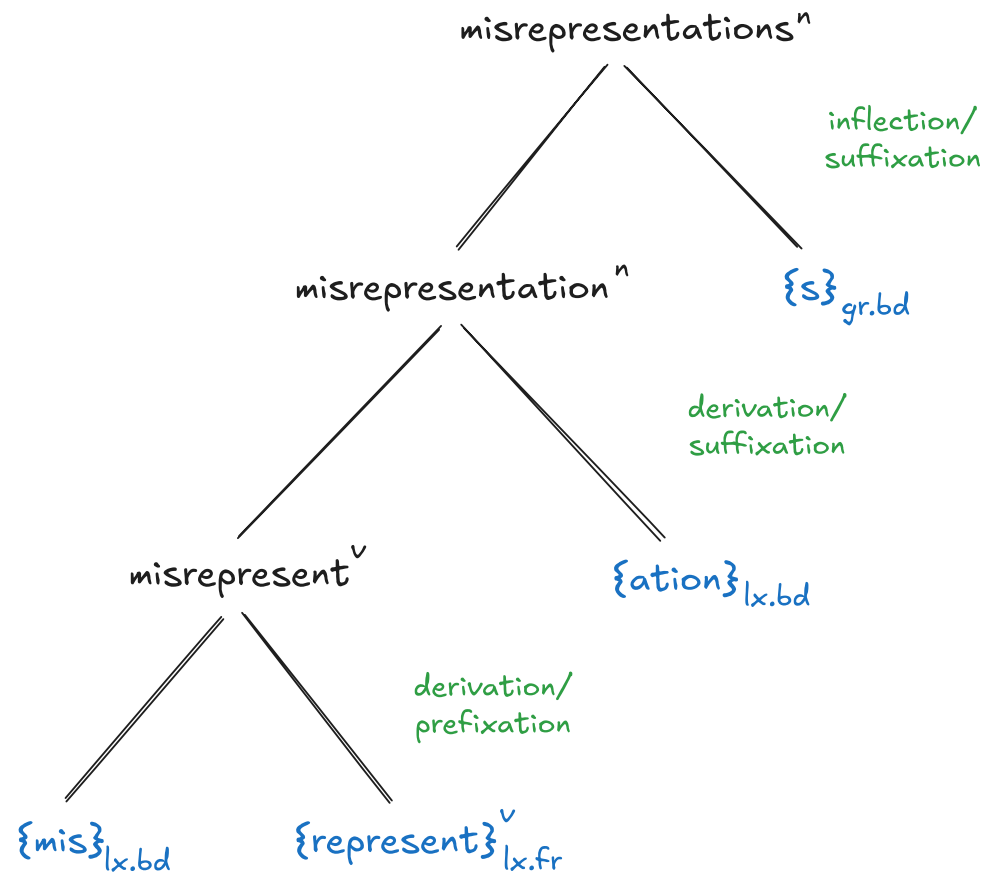
Overview of morphemic word-formation processes

Which morphemic word-formation processes are there?



Exercise: conducting a morphological analysis

Provide a full morphological analysis for the word *misrepresentations*.



Non-morphemic word-formation

Overview

Which non-morphemic word-formation processes are there?

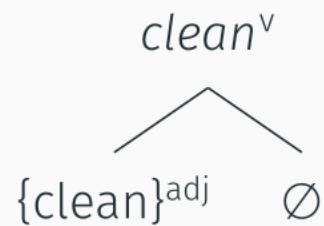
Process	Features	Examples
clipping	parts of words are deleted without a change in meaning	<i>bike, exam, fridge</i>
blending	forms and meanings of words are merged	<i>smog, brunch</i>
acronyms	shortened form retaining the initial letters of compounds or other fixed sequences of words; pronounced as <i>words</i>	<i>NATO, laser, AIDS</i>
initialisms/ alphabetisms	shortened form retaining the initial letters of compounds or other fixed sequences of words; pronounced as <i>sequences of letters</i>	<i>CNN, OED, USA</i>
back-formation	word-class-changing word-formation process which deletes a morpheme or morpheme-like element; longer form pre-existing	<i>babysit</i> / ^v < / <i>babysitter</i>
reduplication	rare word-formation process repeating a word or word-like element either identically or in a slightly varied form	<i>walkie-talkie, hip-hop</i>

Zero-derivation / conversion vs derivation

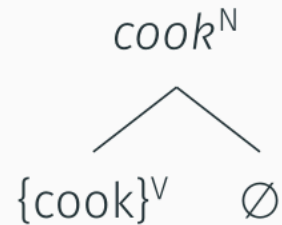
What is the difference between zero-derivation and conversion?

Definition: Creation of a new lexeme by changing the word class of an existing word without the addition of an overtly marked suffix.

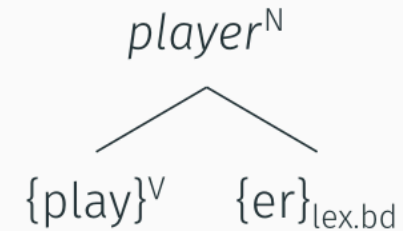
Zero-derivation: Adj > V



Zero-derivation: V > N



cf. derivation:



Compounding vs blending

Compound types

Type	Structure	Example	Paraphrase
endocentric	AB is a type of B	'apple pie'	'an apple pie is a type of pie'
exocentric	AB is neither A nor B, but C	'egg head'	'an egg head is not an egg nor a head, but a person'
copulative ¹	AB is both A and B	'singer-songwriter'	'a singer-songwriter is sb. who is both a singer and a songwriter'

Formal properties of blends

swooshtika – derogatory reference to Nike logo

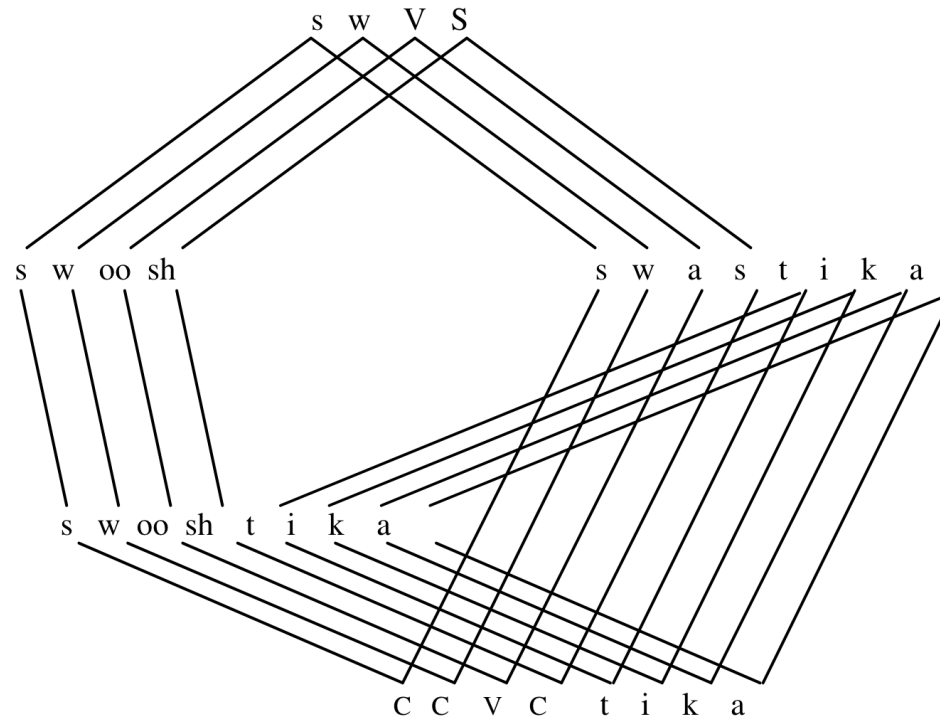


Figure 1. Phonological Relations in an English Blend

Kemmer (2003)

Semantic properties of blends

glitterati

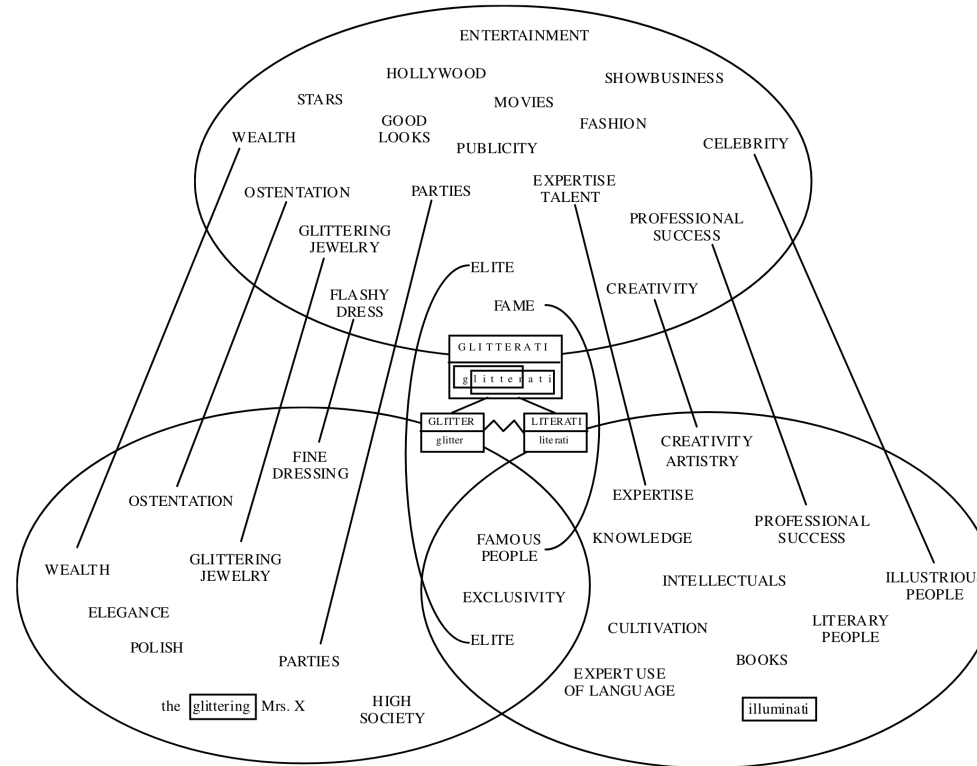


Figure 2. Cognitive Domains in the Blend *glitterati*

Kemmer (2003)

Quiz: classify word-formation
processes

Interactive version

Max challenge attempts exceeded. Please refresh the page to try again!

[Interactive version on Wayground.](#)

Reference answers

Word	Process/type
<i>friendship</i>	derivation
<i>distasteful</i>	derivation (prefix + suffix)
<i>washing machine</i>	compounding (endocentric)
<i>redneck</i>	compounding (exocentric)
<i>singer-songwriter</i>	compounding (copulative)
<i>paperback</i>	compounding (endocentric)
<i>cook</i> (N) ← <i>cook</i> (V)	conversion
<i>to Google</i> (V)	conversion
<i>fridge</i>	clipping
<i>Brangelina</i>	blending
<i>swooshtika</i>	blending
<i>sightsee</i>	back-formation
<i>LOL</i>	acronym/initialism

Morphemic vs non-morphemic WF – summary

	morphemic	non-morphemic	examples
building blocks	morphemes	parts of words	<i>br + unch</i>
combination	adding morphemes	removing parts	<i>in flu enza</i>
serialization	concatenative	interspersed	<i>CHuckLE x snORT</i>
regularity	clear rules, predictable patterns	heterogeneous, high variability	<i>Brangelina</i>
cognitive processing	largely unconscious	conscious coining	<i>BBC</i>

Further reading

- Bauer, Laurie. 2022. *An Introduction to English Lexicology*. Edinburgh University Press.
- Lipka, Leonhard. 2002. *English Lexicology: Lexical Structure, Word Semantics and Word-Formation*. Tübingen: Narr.
- Schmid, Hans-Jörg. 2016. *English Morphology and Word-Formation - an Introduction*. 2nd ed. Berlin: Erich Schmidt Verlag.

References

Kemmer, Suzanne. 2003. "Schemas and Lexical Blends." In *Motivation in Language: Studies in Honor of Günther Radden*, edited by Günther Radden and Hubert Cuyckens, 69–97. J. Benjamins Pub. Co.

Kerremans, Daphné. 2015. *A Web of New Words*. Bern: Peter Lang. <https://doi.org/10.3726/978-3-653-04788-2>.

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